

LEADERSHIP VACUUM

Missing VAJPAYEE

The BJP lacks everything that Vajpayee represents. It badly needs a leader who has the mind to restore his ideas.

The most popular brand of the BJP is invisible and inaudible. He is elsewhere, far away from the power struggle that has brought the party to the brink of an implosion. His absence has suddenly become the biggest void in an organisation in which the ambition of its leaders is incompatible with their capability. What the party needs today is an Atal Bihari Vajpayee. The first Right-wing prime minister of the Republic has already retired from politics. Sadly, the idea of Vajpayee too seems to have gone out of the political culture of the party. A senior leader and a confidant of the former prime minister gets a taste of the jackboot from the dictatorship of the paranoid; the tyranny of the ruling cabal, presided over by the party's tallest leader, systematically pushes 'the outsiders' to the periphery; the marginalised and the penalised overcome fear and openly challenge the leadership; and the RSS, whose essential work is social and cultural, takes the centrestage and plays an active—and high profile—role as the political arbiter... They all point to one overwhelming truth: the BJP may not be in need of a pope but it certainly needs a central moral authority.

That authority is not L.K. Advani, though the man of many makeovers has tried to become a Vajpayee. Indians are too discerning to be conned by a counterfeit Vajpayee. The original was arguably the most indulged



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prime minister of India. He was larger than the party, and a leader of grand gestures. Least interested in petty manoeuvrings and micro-management, the philosopher king only played to history. He was the unifier as well as the reconciler. He exuded power but never threatened. Allies felt at home with him; colleagues looked up to him. He did not stifle arguments, and gave maximum functional freedom to his ministers. He is still the human

MODERATION, RECONCILIATION AND FREEDOM OF DISSENT
were the principles he refused to abandon throughout his tenure
as prime minister. Still, his authority remained unchallenged.